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RANK LIKE CRAZY

How to rank #1 on
Google + ChatGPT in the AI era



VINCENT JOSSE

Read this first

This playbook is what worked on my four websites and on BlogSEO customers' sites over the last 16 months. No theory. Each tactic says what to do, why it works and what to expect.

Start with tactics 1 and 2 this week: on their own they can move your pages up to 10 positions in less than two weeks. Then fix the mistakes in Part 2 and work down the list. Everything is ranked by effort, quickest wins first.

The "Census data" boxes and charts come from BlogSEO's own studies across hundreds of websites and their Search Console data: what Google actually does with real pages, not what the industry assumes.



What's inside

Part 1 The 15 tactics that just work
Ranked by effort, starting with the quickest wins

Part 2 The 10 most common SEO mistakes
What I see most often when auditing websites

Part 3 Nice-to-haves that get faster results
Three setups that shorten the wait

Part 4 How to get backlinks
The efficient ways, ranked by effort

PART 1

The 15 tactics that just work

Tested on e-commerce stores, SaaS products and directories. They assume you have somewhere to publish long-form content: a blog or a guides section.

1 Refresh old content

Open Search Console and list the posts ranking in positions 8 to 20: page two, close to traffic but invisible. Refresh each one: add a section, update the stats, rewrite the intro, add a recent example. Then update the modified date.

Posts jump more than 10 positions within weeks from this alone.

WARNING

Don't just change the date. Google can tell whether the page was actually updated or only re-dated.

CENSUS DATA

Articles peak around two months after publication, then slide 18 points of indexation as they age, while product pages on the same sites hold flat. Publish-and-forget doesn't work for articles. Putting the current year in the title is worth +8 points of indexation on its own, yet only 9.4% of titles carry it.

Indexation by page age (in-sitemap pages, 18 sites)

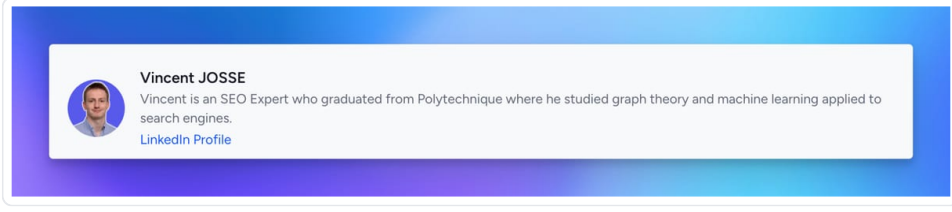


2 Add authors

Google looks for a real human behind the content. It is the core of E-E-A-T (Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, Trustworthiness).

- Add a byline, a short bio and links to external profiles (LinkedIn, X, personal site) on every post
- Create an author page on your site that links out to those profiles
- Add Person schema markup so crawlers get it explicitly (tactic 15)

Each time I apply this to a site that wasn't doing it, all blog posts climb 8 to 10 positions within two weeks.



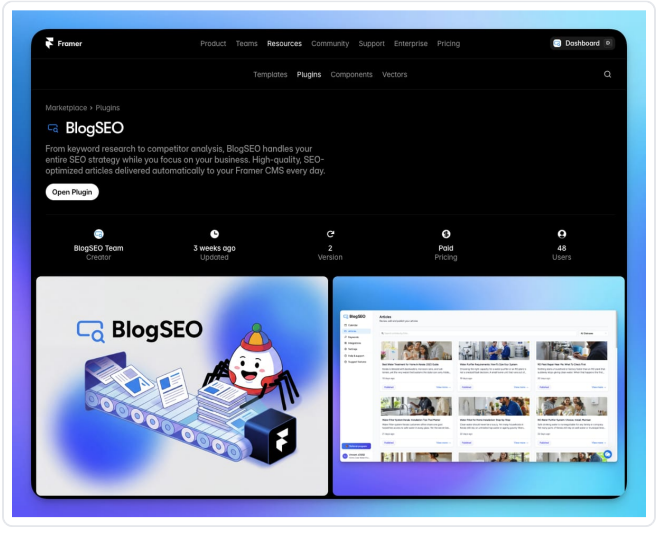
The author box on the BlogSEO blog: bio, credentials and a LinkedIn link

3 Integrations and partnerships

Build an integration with a platform your customers already use and you get a listing on its marketplace: a DA 90+ backlink from a relevant domain, for free, that also sends users.

- **CRM marketplaces:** HubSpot App Marketplace, Salesforce AppExchange, Pipedrive Marketplace
- **Builders and automation:** Webflow, Framer, the WordPress plugin directory, Zapier

BlogSEO's Framer plugin earned a permanent listing on framer.com/marketplace. Build the smallest useful integration for the platform your customers live in.



BlogSEO's listing on the Framer marketplace

4 Exact match domain

If you haven't bought your domain yet, put your primary keyword in it: cheapflights.io for "cheap flights". Google nerfed thin exact match domains years ago, but with quality content it still works. Every article and every natural backlink then reinforces the keyword.

That is why BlogSEO is called BlogSEO: "blog", "SEO" and "SEO blog" are the keywords the business lives on.

> **PRO TIP**
>
> Starting something new? Spend the extra hour finding a domain with your primary keyword in it.

5 Free tools

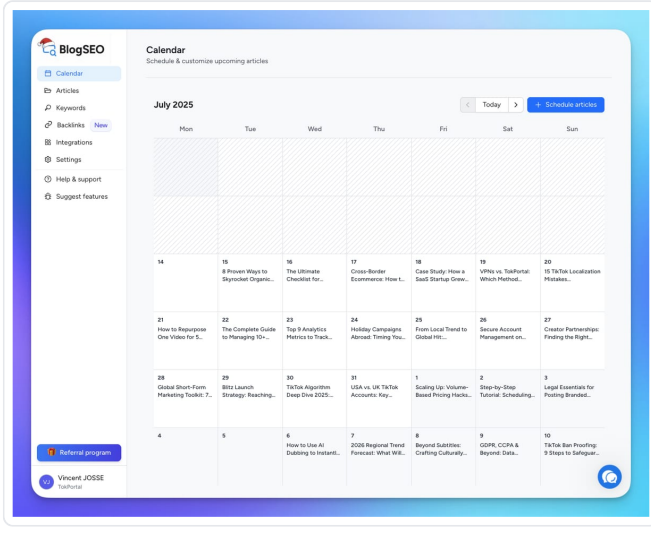
A single-purpose free tool (calculator, checker, generator, analyzer) earns links for years without any outreach. Find one pain point in your niche, build the simplest tool that solves it, make it free.

BlogSEO's free Domain Rating checker (blogseo.io/tools/dr-checker) took a weekend, costs almost nothing to run and brings visitors and links every month.

6 Fresh, regular content

Consistent publishing signals an active site worth crawling often, and every article is a new entry point from search. Pick a cadence you can hold, weekly at minimum, and mix long-tail keywords with pillar pages.

BlogSEO publishes one article a day on each of my blogs automatically. By hand it would cost hundreds of hours a month.



The BlogSEO calendar: one article scheduled every day

CENSUS DATA

Take 282 sites that all started between DR 5 and 25, tracked for about four months. Those that published 60+ articles gained a median +7 Domain Rating. Those that published nothing gained 0. 87% of the heavy publishers gained authority, against 39% of the non-publishers.

Sites that gained authority after about four months



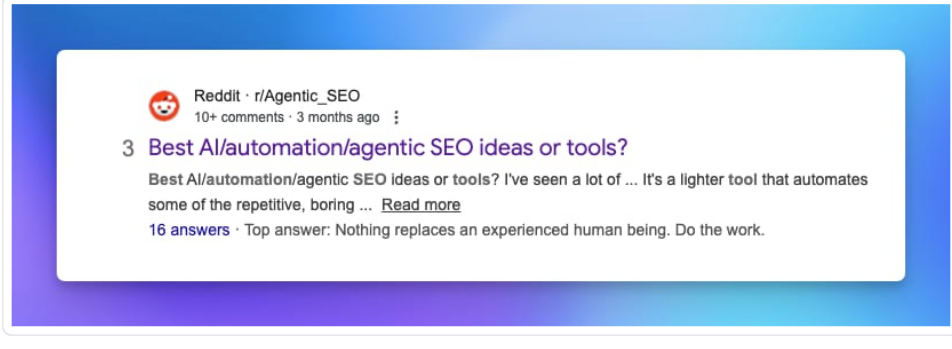
Median Domain Rating change: +7 for the publishers, 0 for the rest.

7 Parasite SEO: YouTube, Reddit and other hosts

Publish where the authority already is. A page on a domain Google already trusts can rank in days for keywords your own site would need months to reach. The hosts that work right now:

- **YouTube is overpowered on high-intent keywords.** Search “best [tool] for [use case]”, “[product] review” or “how to [task]” and a video block sits on page one, above most articles. A 5-minute walkthrough of your product can take that spot within days on a platform Google owns, and YouTube’s own search sends traffic on top
- **Reddit:** Google favors it in results (search anything plus “reddit”), signed a $60M a year data deal with it, and ChatGPT, Perplexity and Claude pull heavily from Reddit threads when someone asks “what’s the best tool for X”
- **Medium, LinkedIn articles, Quora, Substack:** same logic, weaker effect. Use them for keywords your site can’t win yet, and link back to it

> **PRO TIP**
>
> Genuine value first. Answer the question fully and mention your product only when it is the honest answer. Promo-only accounts get removed.



A Reddit thread ranking #3 on Google for “best AI SEO tools”

8 Keyword gaps

Don’t copy your competitors’ keywords. Find the ones they aren’t targeting, or target badly: missed trends, ignored long-tail variations, terms they judged too small.

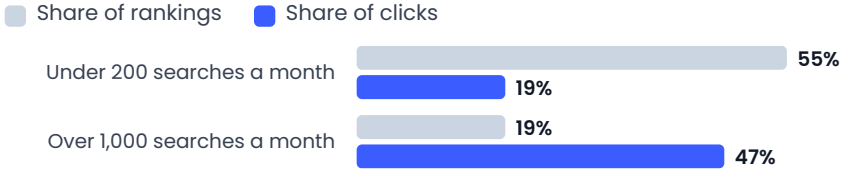
- Run a keyword gap report in Ahrefs, Semrush or a free alternative
- Keep the terms with real volume and no quality content in the results

- Write the best page on the topic. One well-chosen keyword can bring 80% of a niche site's traffic

CENSUS DATA

For the typical site, 2 keywords bring half of all clicks and 4 bring 80%, out of about 40 tracked. Keywords under 200 searches a month are 55% of rankings but only 19% of clicks. Head terms above 1,000 searches are 19% of rankings and 47% of clicks. Click-through peaks in the middle: 1.88% in the 200 to 999 band.

Share of rankings vs share of clicks (3,385 keywords, 178 sites)



PRO TIP

Competition matters more than language. Non-English sites turn impressions into clicks twice as often (1.89% vs 0.93%), and the US and UK bring half the impressions but only a quarter of the clicks. A less crowded market is a keyword gap in itself.

9 NAP consistency and socials

Google cross-checks your name, URL and social links across the web to confirm you are a real entity. Make them identical everywhere.

- **Be present on:** X, Instagram, YouTube, Google Business Profile, Facebook, LinkedIn, TikTok, Crunchbase and F6S
- **Same name, URL and description** on every profile and directory you submit to
- **Social links in your footer** and in your JSON-LD sameAs (tactic 15)

10 High-quality, curated directories

If it is free and anyone can post, skip it. Generic directories and "top 100 startups" lists do nothing. Submit to directories that vet their entries and send traffic:

- **Product Hunt** for SaaS and new digital products

- **There's An AI For That** for AI tools
- **G2 and Capterra** for B2B software

11 Programmatic SEO

One template, thousands of pages, each targeting a specific long-tail keyword, like Zapier's "Connect Slack to Google Sheets" pages. You need three things:

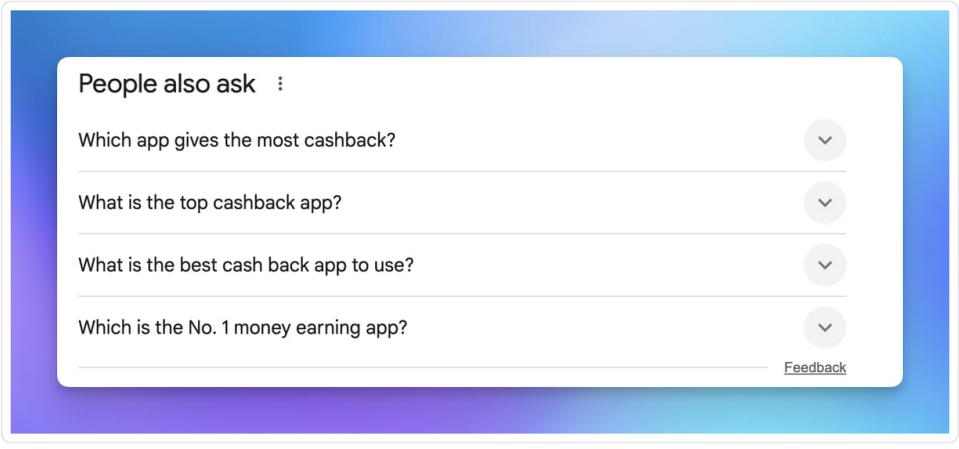
- A good backlink profile, to rank on the long-tail keywords
- A keyword cluster with potential: low competition and enough total volume
- Rich data to populate the template

Put as much genuinely useful information on each page as you can. AI can help, as long as every page serves a distinct intent (mistake 3).

12 Add FAQs

FAQs target long-tail questions, match intent directly and qualify for rich snippets through FAQPage schema. They also feed AI search: a complex question to ChatGPT, Perplexity or Google's AI Overviews fans out into 5 to 10 sub-queries, and an FAQ that answers them directly becomes a source the AI pulls from.

- Use the questions people actually ask: People Also Ask, support tickets, sales calls
- Answer each one directly in a few sentences
- Mark them up with FAQPage schema (tactic 15)



"People also ask": the questions your FAQ should answer

13 Link building outreach campaigns

Cold outreach works, but it is slow. Four proven plays:

- **Guest posting:** write an article for someone else's blog with a link back to your site
- **Broken links:** find broken outbound links on relevant sites (ideally a competitor's) and offer your content as the replacement
- **Unlinked mentions:** find articles that mention your brand without linking and ask for the link; an affiliate link makes the ask easier
- **Reciprocal insertions:** get a mention inserted in an article that already ranks for your keyword, in exchange for one in yours

Expect hours per link and $250+ a month in tools. Reciprocal insertions are risky at scale: a link graph full of reciprocal links looks suspicious to Google. Part 4 covers the faster routes.

14 Comparison pages

Write one page per competitor: "[competitor] alternatives", "[competitor] reviews", "[competitor] vs [your brand]". These searchers have decided to buy and are picking a vendor.

- **For SEO:** bottom-of-funnel keywords, each page ranking independently
- **For ads:** a landing page containing the exact keyword raises ad relevancy and lowers your cost per click on competitor brand bidding

- **Be honest:** admit where your tool is worse. It builds trust and filters out bad-fit customers

15 Actually useful schema markup

JSON-LD tells Google explicitly what your content is. Skip the generic markup; three types move the needle:

- **Person / Author:** ties your content to a real human with external profiles (tactic 2)
- **FAQPage:** qualifies for rich snippets and helps with AI search (tactic 12)
- **SameAs:** lists every place your brand exists online: website, LinkedIn, X, Crunchbase, YouTube (tactic 9)

Most CMS platforms have a plugin; otherwise paste the JSON-LD in your page head. Validate with Google's Rich Results Test before publishing.

PART 2

The 10 most common SEO mistakes

The mistakes I see most often when auditing websites and in BlogSEO's database of thousands of crawled sites. Fix these before adding anything new.

1 Poor internal linking and orphaned pages

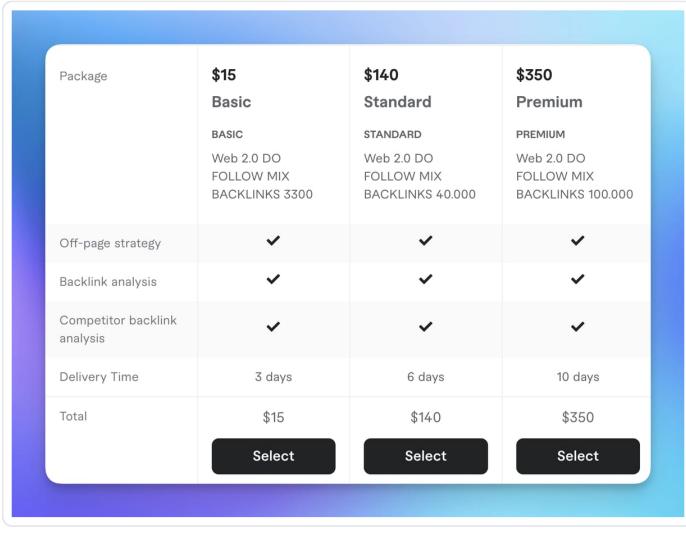
Sites that rank poorly almost always have weak internal linking. The sitemap is necessary but not enough: links tell Google how pages relate and which ones matter.

- **3-click rule:** every important page reachable within three clicks from the homepage
- **No orphan pages:** a page with zero internal links is invisible to Google. Find them with Screaming Frog or Semrush and link to them

2 Buying Fiverr backlinks

"$15 for 3,300 backlinks" buys links from spammy directories, link farms and PBNs Google has already flagged, with zero topical relevance. Best case the links are ignored, worst case your site gets penalized.

> **RULE OF THUMB**
>
> The best backlink is one that brings traffic. A link on a page nobody visits is worthless to Google.

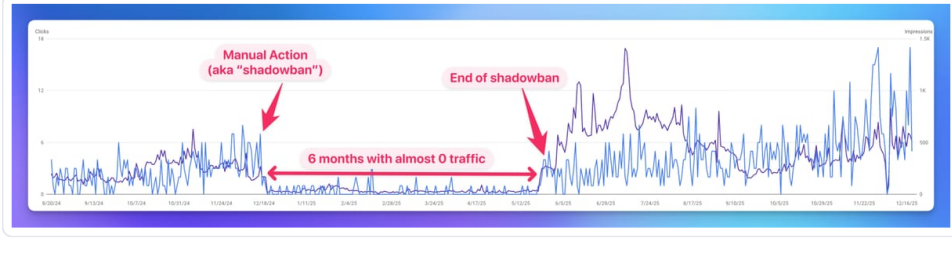


3,300 backlinks for $15. This is what gets sites penalized.

3 Scaling too fast with thousands of low-quality AI pages

Thousands of thin, templated AI pages (same prompt, no E-E-A-T, no unique value) invite a manual action. I have seen traffic die overnight and stay dead for six months. Use AI to scale quality, not to replace it:

- Add unique data or insights that AI can't generate
- Make sure each page serves a distinct search intent
- Scale gradually instead of publishing 10,000 pages at once
- Include real E-E-A-T signals: authors, sources, expertise
- Check your p90 text-to-HTML ratio

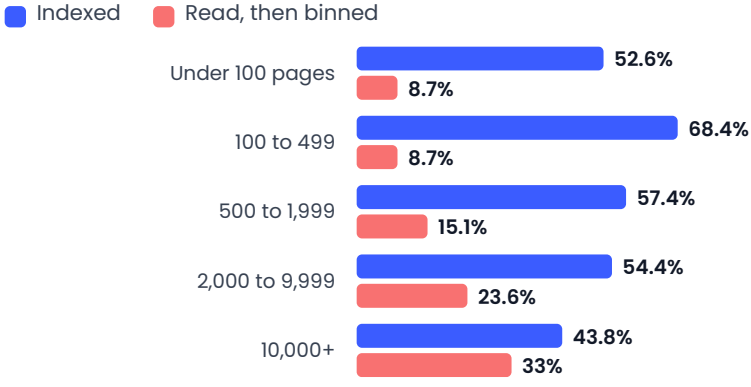


A manual action in Search Console: six months at almost zero traffic before recovery

CENSUS DATA

Size doesn't help indexation, and it hurts yield. Sites over 10,000 pages see a third of what Google reads binned, against 8.7% under 100 pages; indexation peaks at 100 to 499 pages (68.4%). Clicks per indexed page fall from 3.08 under 100 pages to 0.16 above 10,000: a hundred times the pages buys seven times the clicks.

Site size vs what Google does with the pages



4 Crawlability issues

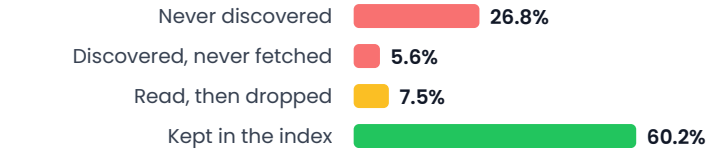
If Google can't crawl your site properly, nothing else matters. Check:

- **Site architecture:** pages buried five or more clicks from the homepage rarely get crawled. Keep it flat
- **Sitemap:** missing, outdated or erroring means Google is flying blind
- **Sitemap bloat:** noindex pages, redirects and low-value URLs waste crawl budget. Only submit pages you want indexed
- **JavaScript redirects:** use real anchor tags for links and server-side (301/302) redirects
- **Broken links:** internal links to 404s waste crawl budget. Audit regularly

CENSUS DATA

Most failing pages are never rejected: Google never showed up. At the average website, 26.8% of pages are never discovered and 5.6% are discovered but never fetched, while only 7.5% are read and dropped. One page in three has never been fetched. Fix discovery before you rewrite anything. And don't panic over "Crawled, currently not indexed": at a normal site it is 3.6% of pages.

Where the average website's pages end up



5 Bad content structure

Your heading hierarchy tells Google, and LLMs, how the content is organized. Keep it sequential: H1, H2, H3, H4.

- **One H1 per page,** with the target keyword in it
- **Don't skip levels:** H1 straight to H3 breaks the hierarchy
- **Headings reflect the actual structure** of the content, not a design choice

> **CENSUS DATA**
>
> Much of the on-page checklist is noise. Within the same website, word count, title length, Title Case, heading count and image count showed zero effect on indexation. What moved the needle: a meta description at all (+9.6 points), the current year in the title (+8 points) and the exact target phrase in the title (+3.8 positions).

What actually moves indexation (within the same site, blog articles)



6 Bad URL slugs

The URL is a ranking signal. /product/a3f8c2e1-9b4d teaches Google nothing; /best-running-shoes-flat-feet describes the page and carries the keyword.

- No UUIDs, database IDs or random strings
- Include the target keyword, keep it short, use hyphens

- Respect the hierarchy: if /shoes/nike-air-jordan exists, /shoes should be a real page
- In programmatic SEO, build slugs from your data (name, location, category), never from primary keys

7 Slow LCP

Largest Contentful Paint measures how fast your main content shows up. Images are the usual culprit, and the classic mistake is lazy-loading the hero image.

- Compress images and serve WebP instead of PNG
- Lazy-load only below-the-fold content; the hero image loads first
- Serve assets from a CDN

> **KEEP IT IN PERSPECTIVE**
>
> Content beats Core Web Vitals. Fix the obvious, then move on. Speed matters most on large sites where crawl budget counts.

8 PBNs

Private Blog Networks worked ten years ago. Today Google detects the footprints (same hosting, similar structure, thin content, unnatural link patterns) and deindexes the network along with the site it was boosting.

This is why the BlogSEO backlink exchange is non-reciprocal: A links to B, B to C, C to A, across independent businesses with real traffic (Part 4).

9 Ignoring Bing

Google has about 90% of search and Bing about 4%. Bing still matters:

- ChatGPT leans on Bing's index (Microsoft owns Bing and a large stake in OpenAI). Not in Bing means rarely cited in AI answers
- Enterprises on the Office suite use Microsoft Copilot, which runs on Bing
- Ecosia and DuckDuckGo are wrappers around Bing. Not on Bing means not on any of them

PRO TIP

Set up Bing Webmaster Tools. It gives more feedback than Search Console on what to fix.

10 Sitemap misconfigurations

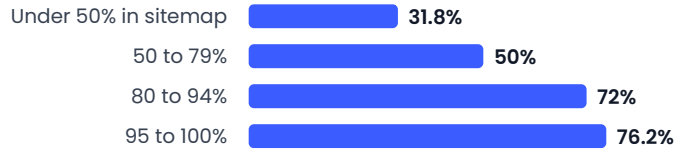
Your sitemap is how search engines learn what to crawl. Common failures:

- **Missing sitemap index:** split sitemaps (blog, products) need an index file listing all of them, referenced in robots.txt
- **Broken sitemaps:** XML errors, wrong formatting, expired URLs. Validate in Search Console
- **Bloated sitemaps:** noindex pages, redirects, 404s and low-value URLs
- **robots.txt mismatch:** the declared sitemap URL must be the right one

CENSUS DATA

Being in the sitemap is worth +42.4 points of indexation, four times more than the rest of the on-page checklist combined. Pages outside it are unknown to Google 59.6% of the time, against 17.1% for pages in it. Sites with under half of their pages in the sitemap index 31.8% of them; at 95 to 100% coverage, 76.2%.

Share of the site in its sitemap vs share indexed (166 sites)



PART 3

Nice-to-haves that get faster results

1 IndexNow

Ping search engines when you publish instead of waiting to be crawled. Bing, which feeds ChatGPT, often indexes within minutes. Most CMS platforms have a plugin; on a custom stack it is one POST request per URL. Google doesn't support it: submit new URLs in Search Console.

2 Static and server-side rendering

Google renders JavaScript slowly, unreliably and at the cost of crawl budget. Server-side rendering or static generation hands the crawler finished HTML. In Next.js or Nuxt it is usually a config change.

Articles indexed after 30+ days, by platform



Once read, Next.js articles are kept at 91.5% and Shopify's at 91.4%. The gap is discovery: Next.js articles go undiscovered twice as often (30% vs 15%).

3 Review at day 30, not day 7

CENSUS DATA

Of articles checked within a week of publishing, 80% came back as "Google has never heard of this URL". Checked again at 31 to 90 days, 90% were indexed. At day 7 you are measuring Google's queue, not your content.

Same articles, asked at two different times (68 sites)



PART 4

How to get backlinks

Relevance and real traffic beat quantity: one contextual link from a page people actually read beats a thousand links from pages nobody visits. Authority also acts as a gate: in our census, sites below DR 20 indexed 55.5% of their pages on average, sites at or above DR 20 indexed 67.2%. From the least effort to the most:

1 The BlogSEO backlink exchange network

The fastest route, and the one I use for my own sites. Members are matched with other members in a related niche, and contextual links to your site are inserted inside articles published across the network, automatically. No prospecting, no cold emails.

- **Non-reciprocal by design:** an algorithm grounded in graph-sparsity research from IP Paris keeps the link graph sparse and asymmetric (A links to B, B to C, C to A), blocks reciprocal pairs and rotates anchor text
- **Real websites, real traffic:** every site is independently owned by a BlogSEO customer publishing genuine content. Links sit inside relevant articles, never in footers or link pages
- **Credits, not cold emails:** every subscription includes monthly backlink credits (100 base credits, plus AI Brain Credits convertible at 1 to 5). A link costs credits equal to the linking site's Domain Rating (10 minimum). Lost links are refunded
- **Links stay** on the linking websites even if you cancel

Connect your website, opt in from the dashboard, and links arrive roughly once a day until your credits are used.



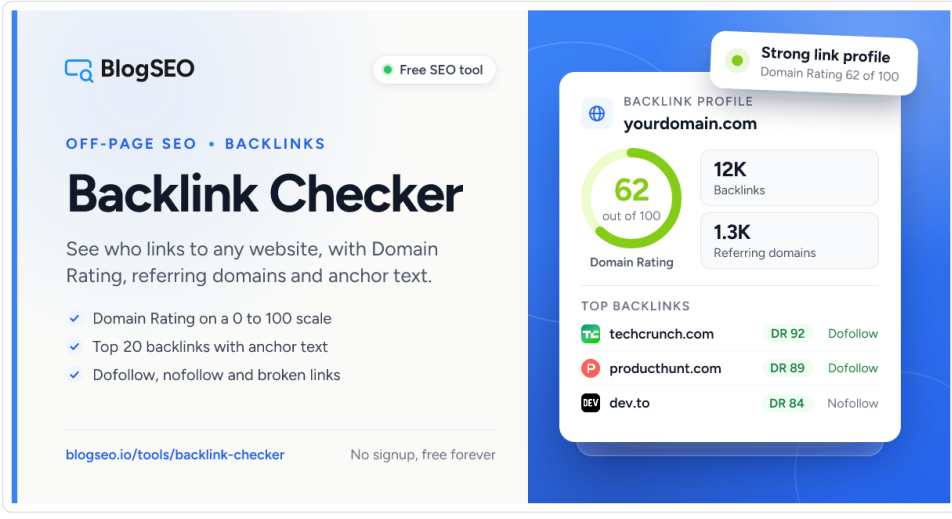
The BlogSEO exchange: contextual links inside real articles across independent sites

2 Integrations and marketplaces

An integration with a platform your customers use earns a permanent DA 90+ marketplace listing that also sends users (tactic 3): HubSpot, Salesforce, Pipedrive, Webflow, Framer, WordPress, Zapier.

3 Free tools

A single-purpose free tool earns links for years without outreach (tactic 5). Calculators, checkers and generators that solve one specific problem get shared and referenced naturally.



Who links to any site: blogseo.io/tools/backlink-checker

4 Curated directories

Skip the free-for-all lists. Submit to directories that vet their entries: Product Hunt, There's An AI For That, G2, Capterra and the niche directories your customers actually browse (tactic 10).

5 An affiliate program

Affiliates write reviews, comparisons and tutorials that link to you from pages with real traffic, exactly the kind of link Google trusts. Pay a meaningful recurring commission (BlogSEO pays 30% recurring for 12 months) and make joining easy.

6 Outreach, when you have time

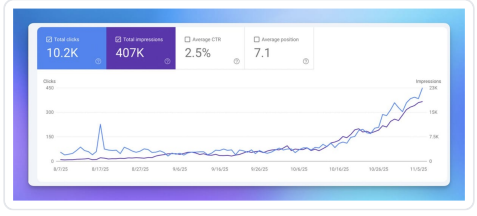
Guest posts, broken-link replacements, unlinked mentions and reciprocal insertions all work (tactic 13). They are slow and hard to scale: a complement, not the engine. And never buy Fiverr links or build a PBN (mistakes 2 and 8).

BEFORE YOU GO

Your first two weeks

Week 1: refresh your page-two posts and add authors (tactics 1 and 2). Week 2: fix internal links, crawlability and your sitemap (mistakes 1, 4 and 10), then set up IndexNow. Review the results at day 30, not day 7.

Then work down the list. The results compound: that is how I grew four websites and BlogSEO itself.



Search Console of a site running the playbook: 10.2K clicks and 407K impressions, average position 7.1

Vincent
Founder @ BlogSEO

blogseo.io · Follow me on X · LinkedIn

Want all of this done for you?
BlogSEO researches, writes and publishes SEO articles for your website every day, and grows your backlinks through the exchange network. In our census, BlogSEO articles ranked at a median position of 11.7 against 16.9 for customers' own posts, with 38.4% in the top 10 versus 27.7%. Free 3-day trial, cancel anytime.

Start for free at app.blogseo.io/signup

About the data

The census figures and charts in this playbook come from BlogSEO's indexation census: 611,503 real pages on 255 websites, checked one by one through Google's URL Inspection API between May and September 2026, plus the Search Console data of the same sites. Every website counts once, so a handful of giant sites can't skew the numbers.